

Good Friendship, Companionship, Good Comradeship is the Whole of the Spiritual Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 18:27

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

This evening, I thought we'd tackle this advice that the Buddha gives us. As you know, Ānanda was the Buddha's attendant for the last twenty years of his life. He was his cousin and he would listen to all the Buddha's talks, and he had a contract with the Buddha when he took on this work that the Buddha would always relate to him anything he'd said when he wasn't there. And he had this phenomenal audio memory.

He would say things, give his opinion, and the Buddha would gently correct him. So one was that he had now really come to understand dependent origination. And the Buddha said, "Oh no, Ānanda, dependent origination is deep, profound," etc. Well, he made the same mistake when it came to the spiritual life.

Ānanda said that he thought good friendship, good companionship and good comradeship were half the spiritual life. And the Buddha said, "Oh no, Ānanda, it is the entire spiritual life, Ānanda, that is good friendship, good companionship, good comradeship. When a person has a good friend, a good companion and a good comrade, it is to be expected that they will develop and cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path." In other words, your *kalyāṇamitra*, your spiritual friend.

So if we just look at those three things and just arbitrary definitions of these different words. If we take good companionship, so a companion is usually somebody who travels with you. So really, it's those who are closest to you: your spouse, your partner, your very close friend. And you can understand that – let's take partners, for instance. If both of them are actually on the same path, I mean, that's a tremendous refuge, isn't it? Even if one is a Tibetan and the other one is a Theravāda, I'm sure they can find some support for each other. So there's that intimacy, an intimate relationship. If that intimate relationship and both people are actually on the same path, that's obviously a great support.

On a wider level, so we talk about good friendship – they're all the people whom you know, apart from those who are close to you. And I think some of you will have found, like I did, that as I moved into the Dharma, became more and more involved, I found that I was losing my interest in the theatre – the local semi-professional theatre that we had in Birmingham at the time. And eventually I stopped going. I didn't

actually say goodbye to anybody. When I look back, I didn't say goodbye to anybody and tell them what I was doing. I just faded out, you might say. And interestingly enough, I can't remember meeting any of them again. And that's part of that movement towards a spiritual life for me. And you might have found that also to be true of yourselves.

When it comes to comradeship, so for me, the word comrade, of course, is associated with the Communist Party – "Comrade Boris." I'm not talking about Big Boris, of course. So that gives us a feel that we're in something that is much bigger than just our personal relationships. And it's something that's very grand. So Buddhism is, of course, a world religion. And it's not only got so many million people who are following the Buddhist path, it also has a massive history – two and a half thousand years. And I think what that does when you reflect on it, it gives you tremendous confidence. You would have thought by now, after 2,500 years, that people would have sussed out whether the Buddha was telling the truth or not, whether it was just a big tall tale.

So when I used to contemplate this about friendship being the entire spiritual life, it never matched up for me. I couldn't quite work out why it should be the entire spiritual life. But then of course I came across Ubuntu.

Now some of you will know it as the open source operating system on Linux. But that's not what I'm actually referring to. Ubuntu is a South African philosophy from, say, Zimbabwe downwards, so the Zulus and the Xhosa people – all those people have this philosophy of Ubuntu. And you can encapsulate it in one small sentence: "I am what I am because of who we all are." I am what I am because of who we all are. In other words, I am my relationships. And I remember Krishnamurti saying that, actually.

So in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the Buddha actually, in the four sections – one on the body, one on feeling, one on mental states, and one on the teachings of the Dharma – there is this recurrent phrase that goes through it. They meditate observing an aspect of the body or feelings or mental states or teaching of the Dharma internally, externally, both internally and externally. And it's this last one that I want to center on. So in other words, the Buddha is asking us to be aware of ourselves, aware of others, but also this interaction that is constantly happening between us.

And if we just take one or two examples, so this body, for instance – I mean, this body that we've got isn't something we chose. I definitely would have chose something better, I think. I just happened to end up with this body because of all the genetic history that came before it. And this body expresses that genetic history. It's part and parcel of that specific genetic history.

When it comes to the body, you see, the food I eat – not only is it grown by others and sold by others, and often cooked by others for me – the actual recipes that we use are usually made up by other people. So there's this constant flow of information about what's nice to eat, what makes a good meal. It's the same with clothes and fashions. The fashions change. Who changes them? Some bright spark has an idea. And then after that, we're all wearing different clothes. I mean, in my own life, my pseudo hippie stage went

around with flowery pants.

And when we look at our dwellings, these are all designed by other people, all the furniture we have in it. And of course, this becomes obvious when you look at different cultures. And then you see different food, different clothes, different ideas of how houses should look, etc. And finally, medicines and care. All these medicines are produced by other people. They're coming into my body. They affect me.

So we get this idea that this body isn't static in any way, not physically. The water that we're drinking – here we've got this chlorine in it. The air that we're breathing is full of CO₂ because of people using fossil fuels and all that. So you can see that the body itself is in a process of communication with the world around it.

And in terms of other areas, we're actually just expressions of our culture. The problem is that this sense of self seems so static. It seems so real. You don't seem to think you change, except when it's obvious that you change. You get this sense of substantiality. But then when you contemplate it, you realize it's just a concept. And the concept holds us in present time, as it were, but unfortunately creates a wrong relationship.

We've got this word proprioception. Proprio means self – perception of self, perception of the body. So you've only got to watch how your body changes, for instance, with whatever you're sitting on: a chair, a metal bench, an armchair, lying on the bed, doing yoga on the floor. We're constantly having to negotiate with the environment around us. And when you're walking with somebody, you have to be in step. If they're walking too fast, you tell them to slow down. If you're walking too slow, you tell them to hurry up. So there's this constant negotiation going on.

If you catch yourself, for instance, with somebody who has authority over you – it could be a policeman – suddenly you feel guilty anyway, even if you've not done anything wrong. But you'll notice that when you're with somebody who has authority over you or whom you respect, who is an authority, whether you like it or not, you'll shrink your body. That's how we express that respect or deference. And in the same way, when we feel ourselves to be in authority or in authority over, you'll lift the body up, you'll pull your shoulders back. And all that's to do with communication.

I don't want to spend too much time on this because there was a video I came across about this poor young kid whose parents thought had an evil spirit. So as a toddler, they put him in with the chickens and basically he became a chicken. And when he got too big for the chicken coop, they put him in an old people's home and tied him to a bed. A woman called Elizabeth Clayton – you can see it, it's on YouTube, there are two videos. One, you see him as a young man and later on as much more socially interactive. But he's actually standing there like a bird. He's got his shoulders like this as though they're flopping wings. It's awful. And he will never be able to speak, never be able to communicate. And what that does for me is it puts in sharp relief how much we owe to our relationships.

Mental states – our mental states are constantly in... We'll notice that our mental states are often affected by the people we're with. So if you're with people who are depressed, who feel down, it pulls you down. I mean, you might try to lift yourself up, but in the end, you might give in. Whereas with people who are in a happy state, who are bubbly, it just lifts you up. So there's this constant communication at the heart level.

And there's also a communication at perceptual level, at a conceptual level. Take something like big concepts like free speech or democracy or something like that. You can see that what we read in the newspapers, what we hear people say on the television and things like that, what we discuss amongst ourselves – constantly our concepts are beginning to change. They move. And what's understood there, there's an actual word for it. It's called a perception.

So, for instance, we all have a concept of an apple. But every time you see an apple, that concept is slightly changed. And so it is with these rather more abstract concepts that we have. And you can see it changes. These change over time. I was just thinking about kings and queens since we have one here and other countries too. But there was a time when you could insult a king or somebody like that. It was *lèse-majesté* and you'd find yourself being whipped or chucked in a jail or worse. And if you think about Putin and Xi Jinping and Kim Jong-un, you can see that depending on the country you're in or where you're at, your concept of how a country ought to be ruled changes. There are people who will support Putin and Xi Jinping and all that. And all these concepts we are absorbing and we are doing our own little interpretation of them, but we're in constant communication.

So I think that sums up this statement by the Buddha. And I just want to return to it. So this is what the Buddha says, you see. He says the entire spiritual life is good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship. And when a person has a good friend, a good companion, a good comrade, it is to be expected they will develop and cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path.

And in his life, you remember, he had these six companions who probably followed him from those times when he was practicing those absorption states to when he was practicing the ascetic practices of almost starvation, really. And remember, when he left them, they didn't want to know him. As far as they were concerned, he'd gone soft. And when he came back, it took them a while to realize that maybe he'd changed. There was a conversation there which comes out when he talks about his new understanding. And he asks them, "Have you ever heard me speak like this before?"

So right there within the Buddha's life, he had these six companions. And if we then understand that within the concept of Ubuntu, "I am what I am because of who we all are" – I am my relationships – so the Buddha is trying to urge us, or at least trying to make us understand that the people around us are our inspiration, they're our support. But they're also supposed to be checks. A good friend tells you when you're not doing things as you ought to be doing them.

So that's what I was centering on. And I just felt that I had a better concept of what the Buddha was talking

about when I came across this teaching or this philosophy of Ubuntu.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your development of good friendship, you will complete the Noble Eightfold Path and be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

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